

# Rights, Facilities, and Challenges for Visually Impaired in India

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## Educational Rights for Visually Impaired

- Although Indian law guarantees education for all, blind children often face exclusion from mainstream schools. For instance, one family's son Pradeep (born blind) was repeatedly denied admission by regular schools ("teachers unable to cope," fear of burdening other students), forcing his parents to send him to a special school for the blind.
- Advocates insist on inclusive education measures: e.g. one expert recommends that if even one blind pupil is in class, textbooks must be provided in Braille and trained aides (such as a Braille-trained assistant) must be available. In practice, teacher training and resources often lag behind.
- NGOs support blind students' learning. The Samrita Trust, for example, provides Braille-based learning devices to visually impaired students from preschool through college, helping them study independently and qualify for jobs. Such efforts aim to fill gaps left by official services.

## Assistive Technologies and Accessibility

- Screen-reading technology can greatly empower blind people, but implementation is uneven. India has no formal "accessibility inspectors," so many employers and public offices lack basic accommodations. In principle, screen readers and speech software enable visually impaired users to work as effectively as anyone, yet most organizations have no standards to support them.
- In everyday life, blind individuals succeed with assistive tech. For example, a visually impaired woman became a voice/accent trainer at a BPO by learning the JAWS software (which vocalizes on-screen text). She attended mainstream schools and college, then used screen-reader software to secure employment at IBM Daksh.
- Braille literacy is critical. Experts stress providing exam materials and classroom text in Braille whenever a blind student is present. Despite this need, availability of Braille books and readers is limited: blind Indians themselves report that "unavailability of readers and literature in Braille" is a top concern.
- Public facilities are gradually becoming more accessible. For instance, a national research library installed ramps, accessible toilets, and computers equipped for visually impaired users, enabling blind scholars to work there independently. Such infrastructure shows progress in accommodating the blind in educational and public institutions.

## Employment and Economic Rights

- The Persons with Disabilities (PWD) Act, 1995 reserves 3% of government jobs for disabled persons, including a 1% share specifically for the visually impaired. The Act even extended job quotas to higher-level positions (A & B categories) that were previously excluded. This has allowed some blind individuals to enter elite services (e.g. IAS officers) that were once inaccessible.
- In practice, implementation remains spotty. One report notes that although the quota scheme was simplified and enabled blind candidates to clear prestigious exams, disabled applicants still face hurdles and must repeatedly prove their eligibility. Reservation rules also exclude many impairment groups, but sighted-blindness is explicitly covered (1% in most disability schemes).
- Financial assistance varies by disability. For example, the state of Haryana historically gave larger unemployment stipends to blind recipients (₹400–600) than to other groups. Recent policy changes equalized allowances (a flat ₹1,000–2,000 for all educated disabled unemployed). Tax and benefit concessions often favor the blind: e.g. middle-class income-tax exemptions and housing/tuition rebates are granted to visually impaired persons without the strict disability threshold others face.
- Despite legal measures, overall employment rates for disabled (including visually impaired) have remained low. A World Bank study found that by 2002 only ~38% of disabled persons were employed (down from 42.7% in 1991), indicating that barriers to hiring and workplace inclusion persist despite policies.

## Social Attitudes and Representation

- Indian culture often stereotypes blindness as a fatal flaw. In mythology, for example, the blind prince Dhritarashtra was deemed unfit to rule, underscoring long-held beliefs that “loss of sight makes one incompetent.” Famous blind Indians like writer Ved Mehta have lamented that society views blindness as akin to begging or “fate reserved for beggars.” Such attitudes contribute to widespread stigma and pity.
- Misconceptions and patronizing behavior are common. One anecdote notes that people speaking to a blind person instinctively raise their voice as if the person were also deaf. More broadly, many assume the blind are non-sexual or incapable of normal life: young women with visual impairments report pressure and misunderstanding around marriage and sexuality, and even fear of having children. (By contrast, blind girls like Radhika and Puja in Delhi vocally reject the idea of abortion – they argue disabled children deserve identity and life.)
- Media portrayal often misses real blind experiences. Films and TV frequently use able-bodied stars to depict disabled characters (“disability drag”), which keeps disability out of community view. This dramatization can misrepresent the challenges and capabilities of visually impaired people, reinforcing myths rather than showing authentic lives.
- Language is changing, however: official and advocacy circles now prefer terms like “visually impaired” instead of outdated slurs or even “blind,” reflecting a shift toward respectful identity. As one author notes, India has moved away from terms like “cripple”

or “lame” in favor of “visually impaired” (and other person-first terms). This linguistic shift is part of a broader effort to dignify disability in public discourse.

## Identity and Advocacy

- **Community mobilization:** Government-run blind schools and institutions helped launch a rights movement among India’s visually impaired. Scholars note that such schools initiated the politicization of the visually challenged and spurred self-advocacy. In the 1990s, activists (such as Javed Abidi) formed groups like the Disability Rights Group, organized vigils and hunger strikes, and lobbied for the 1995 Act. More recently, blind individuals have protested discrimination directly (e.g. in 2006 Maharashtra police brutally attacked a group of visually impaired men rallying against government exclusion).
- **Identity politics:** Blind people navigate both unity and difference within the broader disability movement. On one hand, collective labels (e.g. “visually impaired”) have enabled advocacy for shared accommodations and policies. On the other hand, experts warn against assuming all blind people have the same experience or opinions. For example, a policy issue that helps the blind (like a tax concession) might not help others, and vice versa. Internal debates continue about whether grouping all visually impaired into one political category helps or imposes rigid identities.
- **Intersections:** Visually impaired persons also face layers of marginalization (gender, class, caste). Some rights activists caution that movements often reflect urban, middle-class blind voices, while rural or intersectional concerns may be overlooked. The struggle for equal rights is entangled with other social identities, meaning that a Dalit blind person’s politics may differ from those of a sighted Dalit or a wealthy blind urbanite. Understanding these differences is seen as essential to building an inclusive vision of disability rights.